

Module 3 Note

Applied Design Fundamentals — Figma Structure, Typography, Grids, Wireframes & Testing

1. Frames, Layers, and Basic Shapes

Understanding Figma's core layout structures is essential for creating responsive and scalable user interfaces.

Container Concept	Core Function	Key Capabilities
Frames	Acts like a canvas/viewport with structural properties. Can be nested inside other frames.	Supports layout grids, auto-layout, constraints, clipping content, and clip bounds.
Groups	Combines multiple objects into a single organizational layer without structural behavior.	Resizes all child elements proportionally; lacks constraints or independent grids.
Layers & Shapes	Individual canvas items arranged in visual stacking order.	Upper layers obscure lower layers; building blocks for vectors and components.

2. Typography, Text Hierarchy & Best Practices

Typography establishes visual structure, legibility, and brand personality across digital interfaces.

Core Typographic Principles:

- **Text Hierarchy:** Use distinct font sizes, weights, and line heights to differentiate Display/H1 headers, section H2s, and readable Body text (14px–16px baseline).
- **Line Height (Leading) & Tracking:** Set comfortable line spacing (typically 130%–150% of font size for body text) to optimize reading comfort.
- **Font Selection:** Limit designs to 1–2 font families to maintain visual harmony and simplify brand consistency.

3. Grid Systems, Constraints & Manipulation

Grid systems and constraints ensure responsive design across mobile, tablet, and desktop viewports.

Key Concepts:

- **Column Grids:** Common standards include 4 columns for mobile, 8 for tablet, and 12 for desktop viewports.
- **Gutters & Margins:** Gutters define column gaps; margins define padding at page edges.
- **Constraints:** Tell child elements how to anchor or scale (Left, Right, Center, Scale, Pin to Top/Bottom) when parent frames resize.
- **Boolean Operations & Masks:** Combine shapes using Union, Subtract, Intersect, and Exclude or create custom masks for cropped visual fills.

4. Wireframing & Rapid Prototyping

Moving from low-fidelity wireframes to rapid interactive prototypes allows quick validation of ideas.

- **Wireframes:** Low-fidelity blueprints focusing purely on content placement, layout structure, and functional hierarchy without visual styling or brand details.
- **Rapid Prototyping:** Linking screens using clickable triggers to quickly demonstrate user pathways, navigation logic, and core interactions.

5. Usability Testing & Scripting

Testing uncovers real friction points and validates interface logic before engineering implementation.

- **Test Plans & Tasks:** Craft non-leading, goal-oriented scenario tasks (e.g., "Find and select a table for two people") rather than explicit UI instructions.
- **Observation & Synthesis:** Record task success rates, time on task, user errors, and qualitative feedback using standardized usability cheat sheets.